

# Oil Tracker: US Gasoline Market Tightening; Global April Deficit May Be Less Large Than Expected

- Prompt Brent/WTI crude nearby futures increased by 5/7% week-over-week to \$105/101 as flows through the Strait of Hormuz remained very low ([Exhibit 5](#)) and on limited signs of progress on a [US-Iran deal](#).
- The US gasoline market has become very tight, with inventories drawing at a rapid average pace of 0.7mb/d since April 1st to 5% below their historical seasonal median this week ([Exhibit 1](#)).
  - This has been driven by a combination of:
    - **Surging net exports demand.** US gasoline net exports are up 0.34mb/d year-over-year (4-week average) ([Exhibit 8](#)).
    - **Resilient domestic demand.** Gasoline demand is resilient at just 0.2mb/d below its year-ago level ([Exhibit 20](#)), and we are now entering the summer driving season.
    - **Price incentives to shift production to distillates.** Strong jet fuel and diesel margins are incentivizing refineries to [increase yields](#) of those products.
  - Wholesale gasoline prices in the US are approximately 15% (\$21/bbl) higher than in Asia and Europe ([Exhibit 1](#)), and US retail prices are just \$0.5/gal below their all-time high ([Exhibit 16](#)).
  - While not our base case, the probability of US oil export restrictions likely rises with US retail gasoline prices.
- The IEA estimates in its latest Oil Market Report (OMR) an April deficit of 5.3mb/d, suggesting that the deficit may be less large than we estimated last month ([Exhibit 2](#)), driven by:
  - **Slightly lower IEA demand.** Since the beginning of the crisis, the IEA has cumulatively (May - Feb OMR) downgraded its estimate of April demand by 3.1mb/d to 100.4mb/d (vs. a slightly smaller downgrade of 2.9mb/d in our balance).
    - **By product:** Net cumulative downgrades by the IEA were largest (in mb/d terms) for LPG and ethane (11%), naphtha (13%), and jet and kerosene (7%) ([Exhibit 3](#)), for which we have also been seeing the [highest risks of scarcity of supply](#).
    - **By region:** Net cumulative downgrades were largest for the Middle East (11%), China (5%), EM Asia ex China ex India (5%), and OECD

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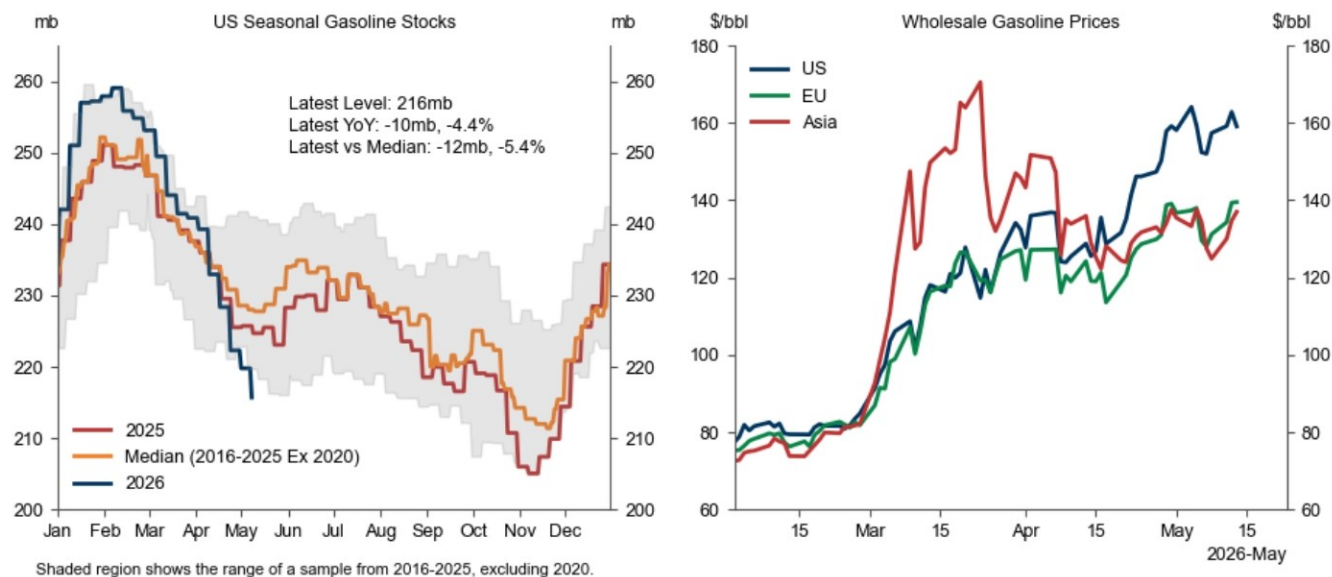
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Asia Oceania (7%) ([Exhibit 3](#)). Notably, the IEA upgraded US demand from last month's OMR by 0.5mb/d on resilient diesel and gasoline demand.

- **Less large IEA drop in Middle East Supply.** The IEA estimates Gulf (defined as Iran, Iraq, Kuwait, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, UAE) crude supply in April at 15.0mb/d, which is 4.0mb/d higher than our balance estimate (11.0mb/d) and 1.2mb/d higher than OPEC secondary sources (13.8mb/d)<sup>1</sup>.
  - The IEA supply beat relative to our balance estimate was driven primarily by Iran and the UAE, likely reflecting less binding storage constraints than expected due to untrackable storage capacity.
- The IEA reports that SPR releases from IEA countries averaged 2.1mb/d in April (but picked up significantly in the second half of the month), which is in line with our tracking. This has been a significantly larger offset for crude than for refined products—of the 90mb of total government inventories released since March 11th, 82mb are crude oil, while only 8mb are refined products.
- US production in 2026Q1 also surprised to the upside, with the modest beats concentrated in oil production by E&Ps (+2.1%) and liquids production by majors (+1.3%) ([Exhibit 4](#)).

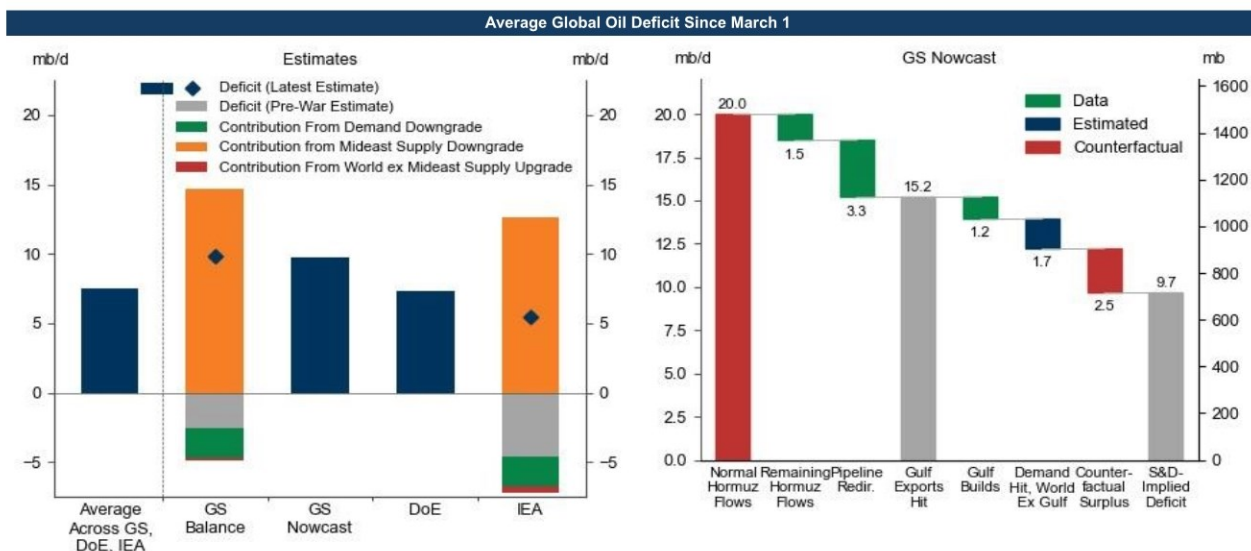
### Charts of the Day

**Exhibit 1: US Gasoline Inventories Have Drawn Sharply to 5% Below The Historical Seasonal Median; Wholesale Gasoline Prices Are 15% (\$21/bbl) Higher in the US Than in Asia/EU**



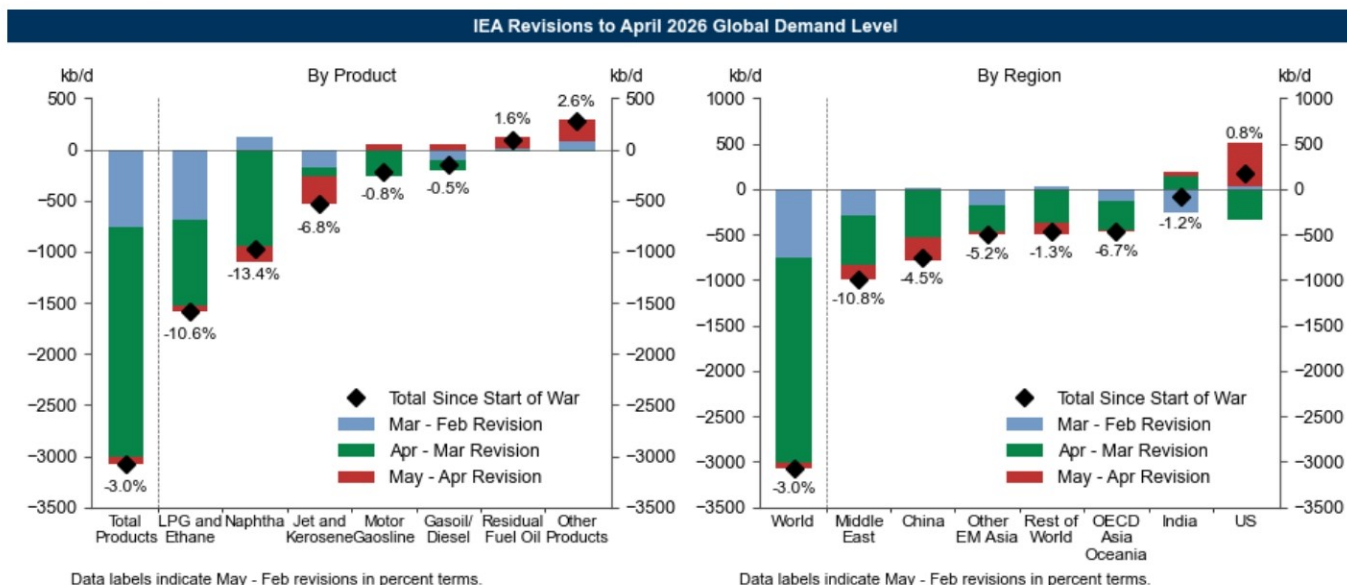
Source: DOE, Platts, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

<sup>1</sup> This estimation uses IEA data for Qatar.

**Exhibit 2: Averaging Across Estimates Suggests That the Oil Market Has Been in a Deficit of 7-8mb/d Since March 1st**

To estimate the May global deficit for IEA, we assume OPEC production remains flat at April levels.

Source: IEA, EIA, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

**Exhibit 3: IEA Downgrades to April 2026 Demand Are Largest for LPG and Ethane, Naphtha, and Jet/Kerosene, and for the Middle East and Asia**

Source: IEA, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

**Exhibit 4: US Majors and E&Ps Modestly Exceeded Production Expectations in 2026Q1, With Positive Surprises Concentrated in Oil Production by E&Ps and Liquids Production by Majors**

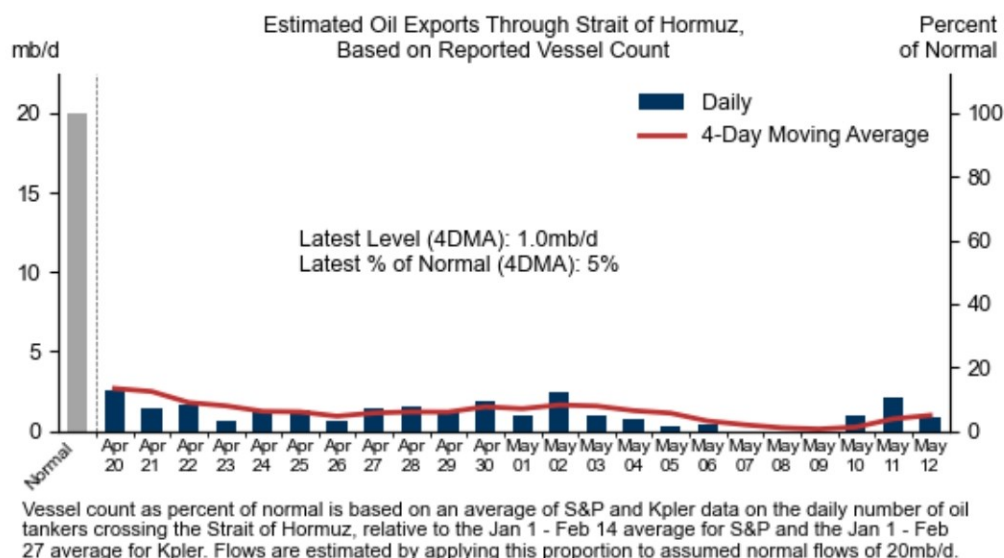
| Surprises in 2026Q1 US Production by Public Firms |                 |                    |                                |                             |
|---------------------------------------------------|-----------------|--------------------|--------------------------------|-----------------------------|
|                                                   | Realized (kb/d) | GS Expected (kb/d) | Realized vs GS Expected (kb/d) | Realized vs GS Expected (%) |
| <b>Liquids, Majors*</b>                           | 4,346           | 4,292              | 54                             | 1.3                         |
| <b>Oil, E&amp;Ps Only</b>                         | 2,812           | 2,753              | 59                             | 2.1                         |
| <b>NGLs, E&amp;Ps Only</b>                        | 1,860           | 1,863              | -3                             | -0.1                        |
| <b>Liquids, Majors and E&amp;Ps</b>               | 9,018           | 8,908              | 110                            | 1.2                         |

\*Majors are defined as XOM, CVX, and COP. E&Ps are the other US producers covered by our GS equity research team.

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

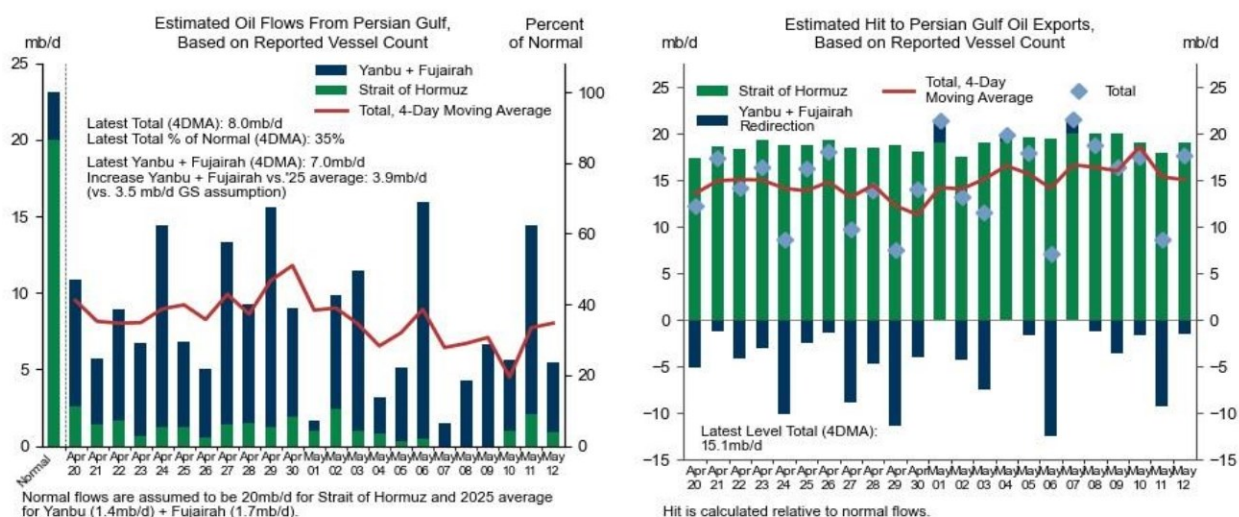
## 1) Persian Gulf Exports

**Exhibit 5: Based on Reported Vessel Counts, We Estimate That Average Daily Flows Through the Strait of Hormuz Are Down 95% from Their Normal Levels (4-Day Moving Average)**



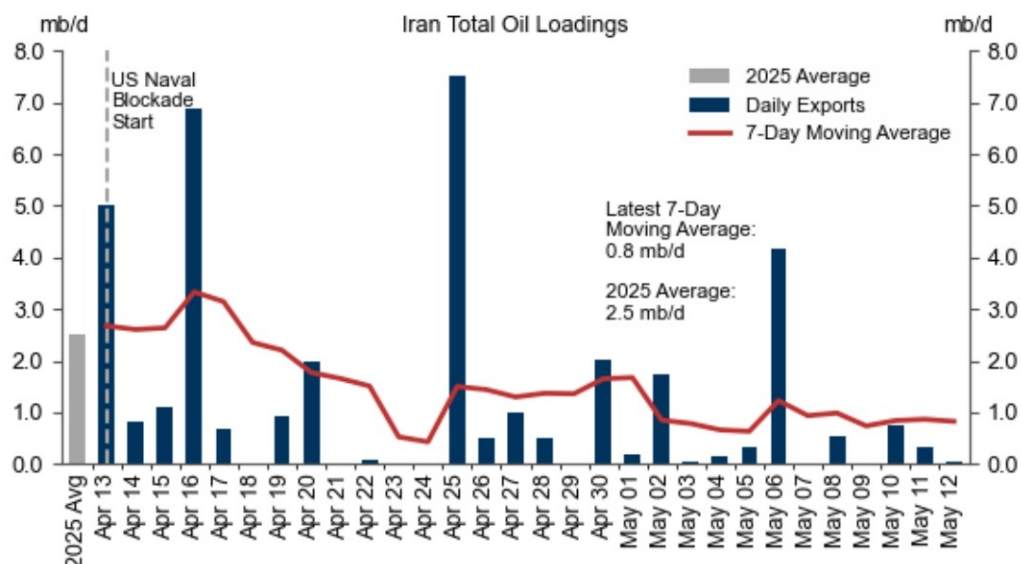
Source: S&P Global Commodities at Sea, Kpler, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

**Exhibit 6: The Estimated Total Hit to Oil Flows from the Persian Gulf Is Currently at 15mb/d**



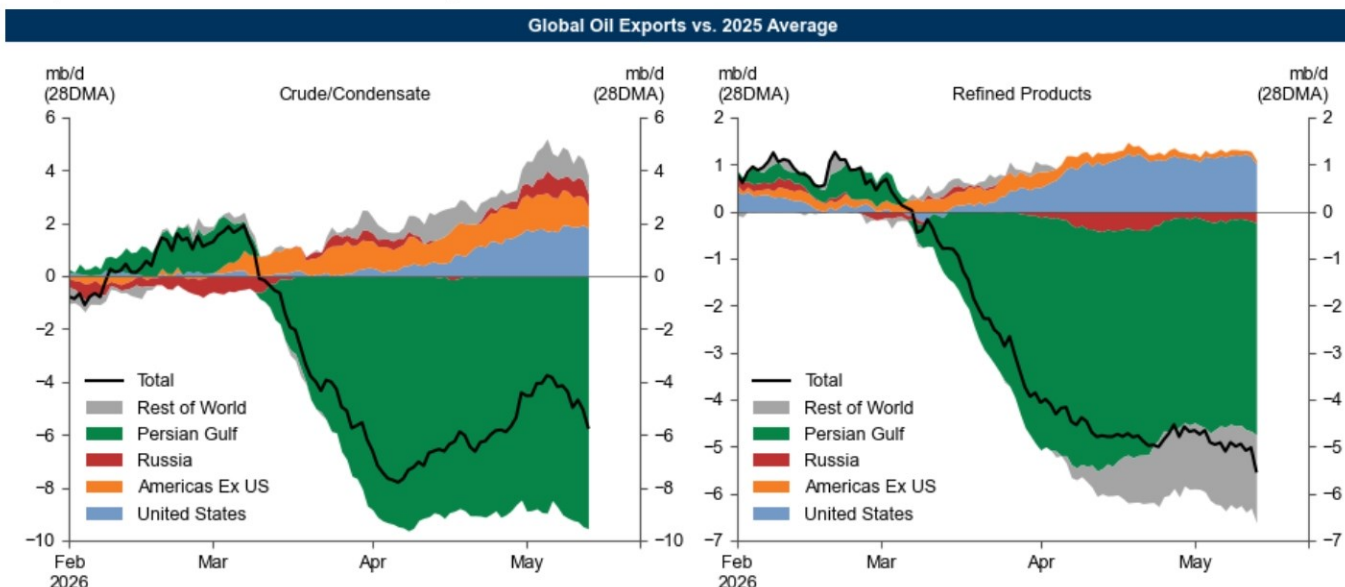
Source: S&P Global Commodities at Sea, Kpler, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

**Exhibit 7: Total Estimated Oil Loadings from Iran Stand at 0.8mb/d (7-Day Moving Average), or 1.7mb/d Lower Than the 2025 Average**



Source: Kpler, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

**Exhibit 8: 40% of the Hit to Persian Gulf Crude/Condensate Exports Is Currently Being Offset, With Contributions from the US/Americas Ex US/Russia of 19pp/8pp/5pp; World Ex Middle East Refined Products Exports Are Now Contributing 1mb/d to the Hit, Rather Than Offsetting It**

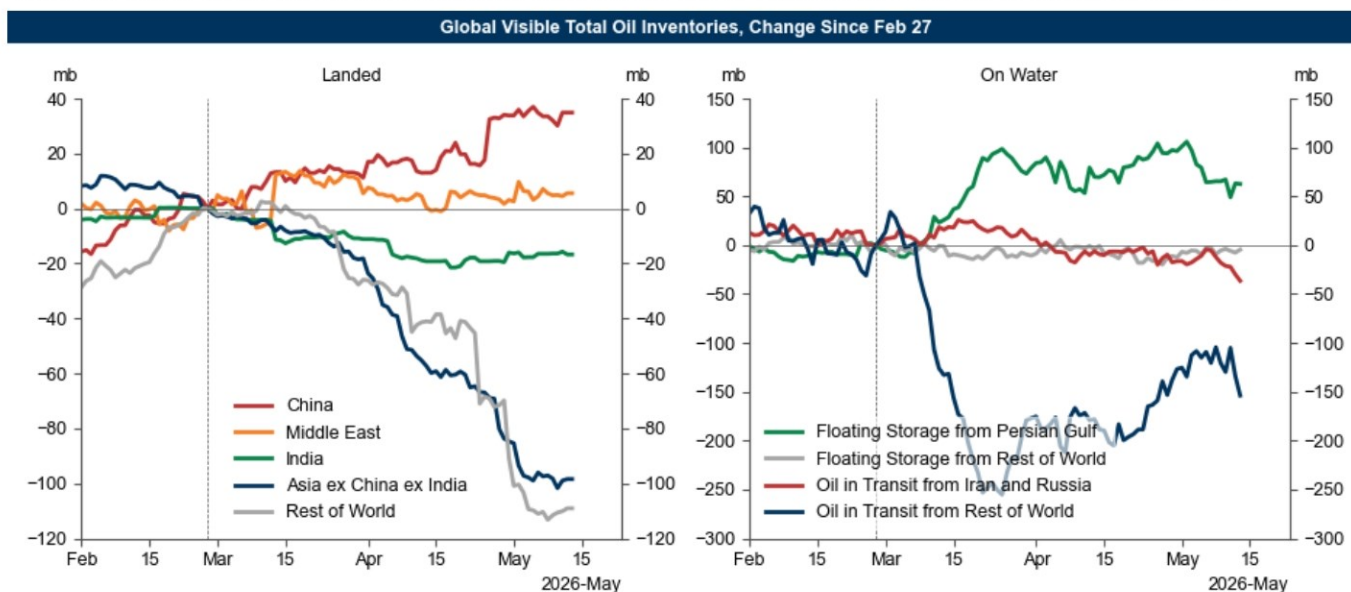


Refined products include LPG.

Source: Kpler, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

## 2) Inventories

**Exhibit 9: Global Visible Oil Inventories Have Drawn Sharply Since Late February Outside of China and the Gulf**



Source: IEA, Kpler, DOE, Euroilstocks, ARA PJK, PAJ, Haver, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

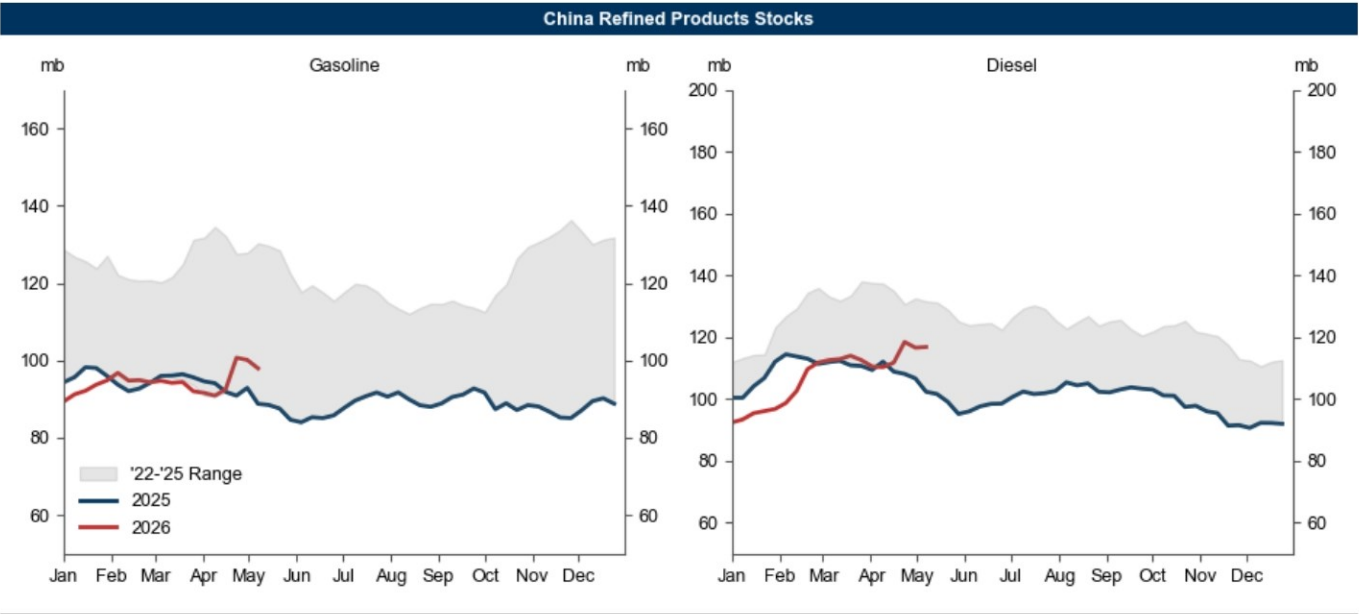
**Exhibit 10: Global Visible Draws Have Averaged 4.4mb/d Since March 1st**

| Visible Oil Stocks, Month-Over-Month Changes (mb/d) |       |       |      |                         |
|-----------------------------------------------------|-------|-------|------|-------------------------|
|                                                     | March | April | May  | Average Since March 1st |
| <b>Global Visible Stocks</b>                        | -4.7  | -2.5  | -7.5 | -4.4                    |
| <b>Landed Crude Stocks</b>                          | 0.1   | -2.4  | -2.2 | -1.3                    |
| OECD                                                | 0.3   | -2.6  | -2.6 | -1.4                    |
| China                                               | 0.3   | 0.3   | 0.4  | 0.3                     |
| Non-OECD Ex China                                   | -0.5  | 0.0   | -0.1 | -0.2                    |
| <b>Landed Products Stocks</b>                       | -1.3  | -1.5  | -0.8 | -1.3                    |
| OECD NGL                                            | -0.3  | 0.2   | 0.4  | 0.0                     |
| OECD Refined Products                               | -0.9  | -1.8  | -0.8 | -1.2                    |
| Non-OECD Total Products                             | -0.1  | 0.1   | -0.4 | -0.1                    |
| <b>Oil on Water</b>                                 | -3.5  | 1.4   | -4.5 | -1.7                    |
| Floating Crude                                      | 1.5   | 0.5   | -1.6 | 0.6                     |
| Floating Products                                   | 0.7   | 0.0   | -0.4 | 0.2                     |
| Crude in Transit                                    | -3.9  | 1.1   | 0.5  | -1.1                    |
| Products in Transit                                 | -1.8  | -0.3  | -3.1 | -1.4                    |

Latest observation is today, and data is unsmoothed. "Crude" categories (landed and on water) include both crude and condensate. Month-over-month changes are calculated by taking the end-of-month level, subtracting the previous month's end-of-month level, and dividing by the number of days.

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

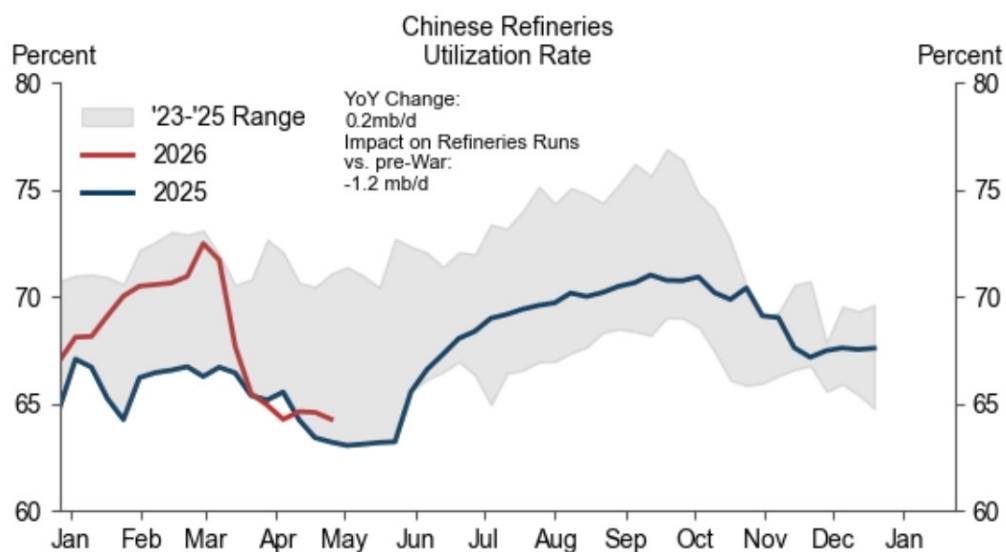
**Exhibit 11: China Longzhong Gasoline Stocks Edged Down by 2mb Week-Over-Week But Remain 9mb Above Year-Ago Levels; Diesel Stocks Remained Resilient and Stand 14mb Above Year-Ago Levels**



Source: MySteel, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

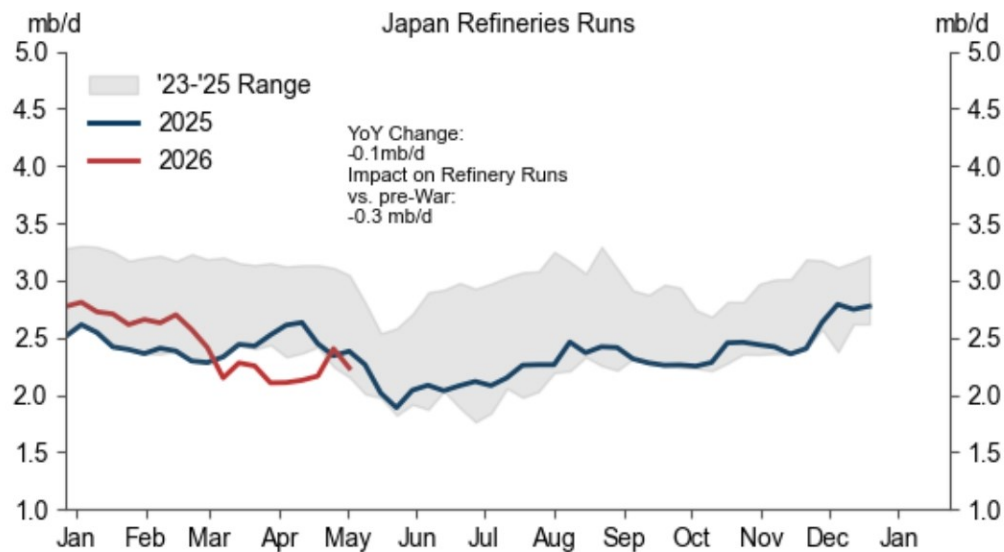
### 3) Refining

**Exhibit 12: Chinese Refineries Runs Have Declined by 1.2mb/d Since the Outbreak of the Conflict**



Source: Oilchem, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

**Exhibit 13: Japanese Refineries Runs Are 0.3mb/d Lower Than Their Pre-Conflict Levels**

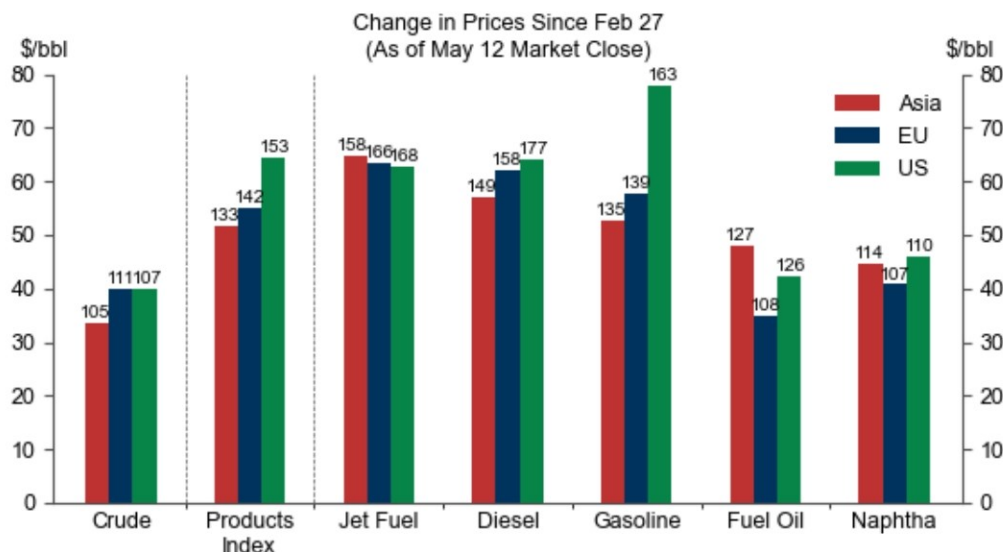


Source: PAJ, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

## 4) Energy Prices

### Energy Prices Across Regions

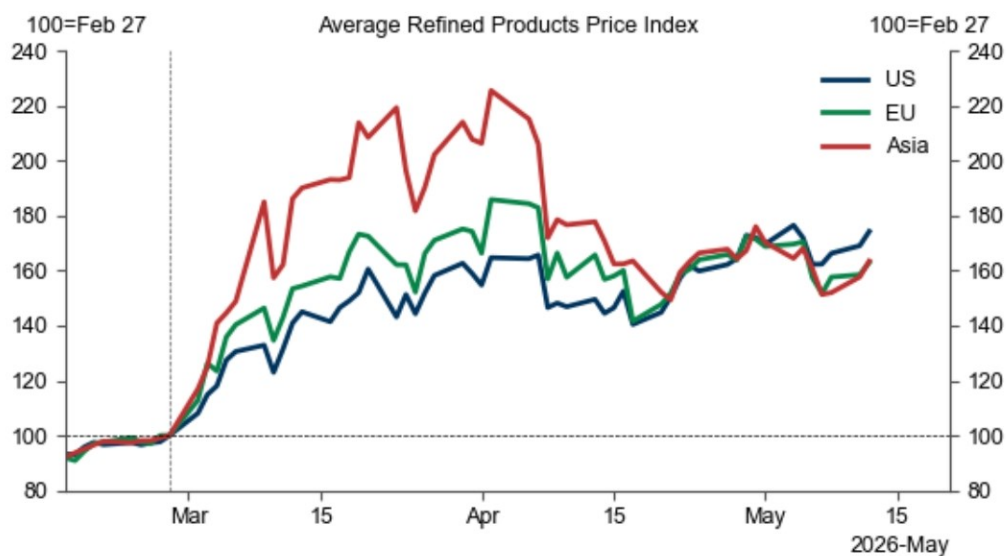
**Exhibit 14: US Jet Fuel, Diesel, and Gasoline Prices Increased the Most Since Last Week**



Bar labels indicate crude/refined products prices as of May 12th market close. We consider cash or cash-equivalent prices.

Source: ICE, Platts, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

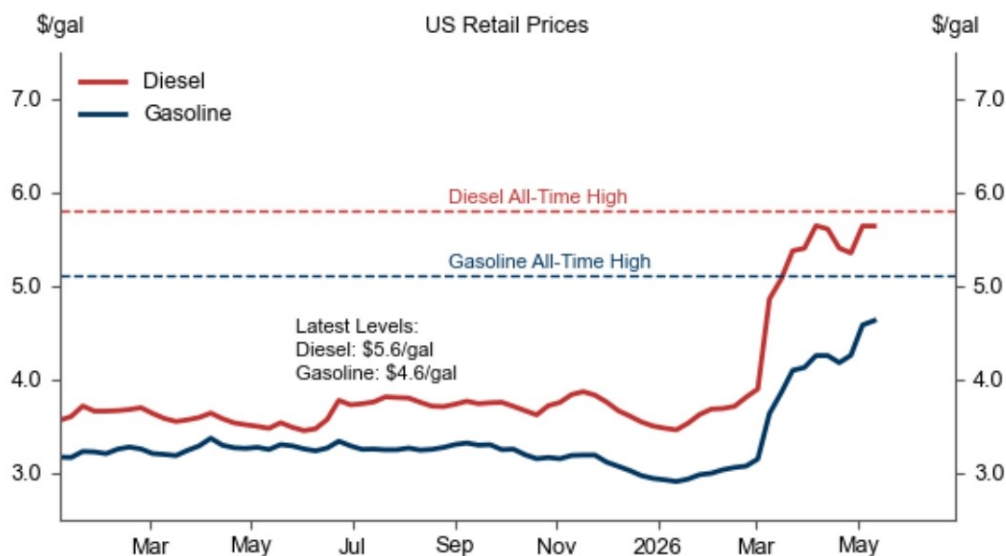
**Exhibit 15: The US Refined Products Price Index Is Currently 7% Higher Than Its Asia/EU Counterparts, as Market Tightness Has Spread From East to West**



We take a weighted average of products prices of gasoline, diesel, jet fuel, fuel oil, and naphtha based on the relative 2025 average demand share of each product (after rescaling the February 27, 2026 data point to 100) for each region. We consider cash prices for refined products.

Source: Platts, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

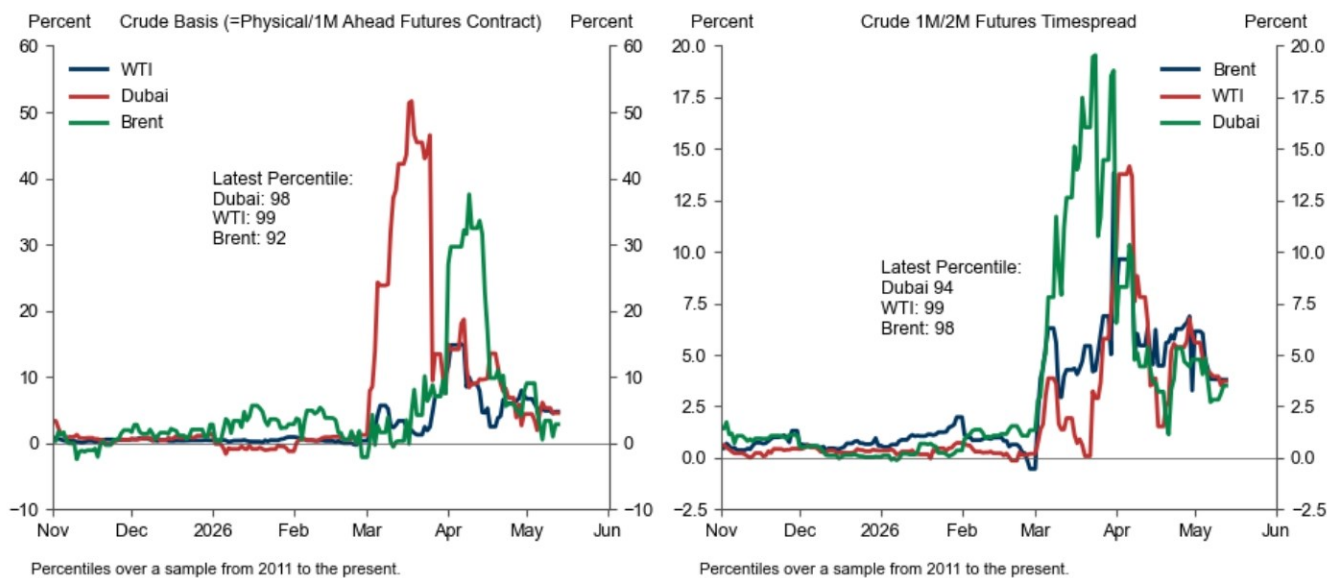
### Exhibit 16: US Retail Diesel and Gasoline Prices Remain Just \$0.2/gal and \$0.5/gal Below Their Respective All-Time Highs



Source: EIA, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

### Crude Prices

### Exhibit 17: Prompt Timespreads Across Regions Have Converged to High Levels

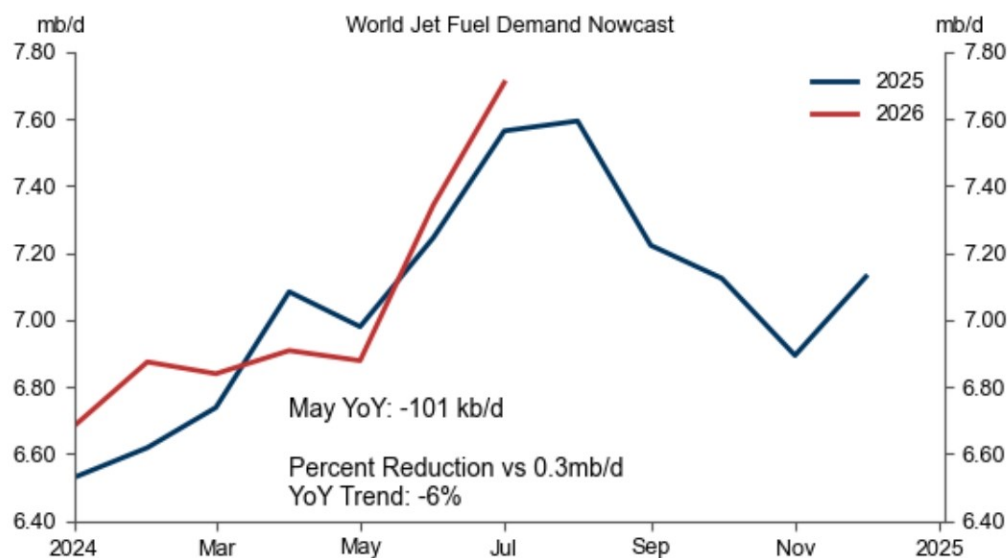


Basis represents the difference (in % of 1M ahead futures) between spot physical crude futures and 1M ahead financial futures. We include Brent, Dubai, and WTI in crude basis on the left panel and in 1M/2M timespreads on the right panel.

Source: Platts, CME, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

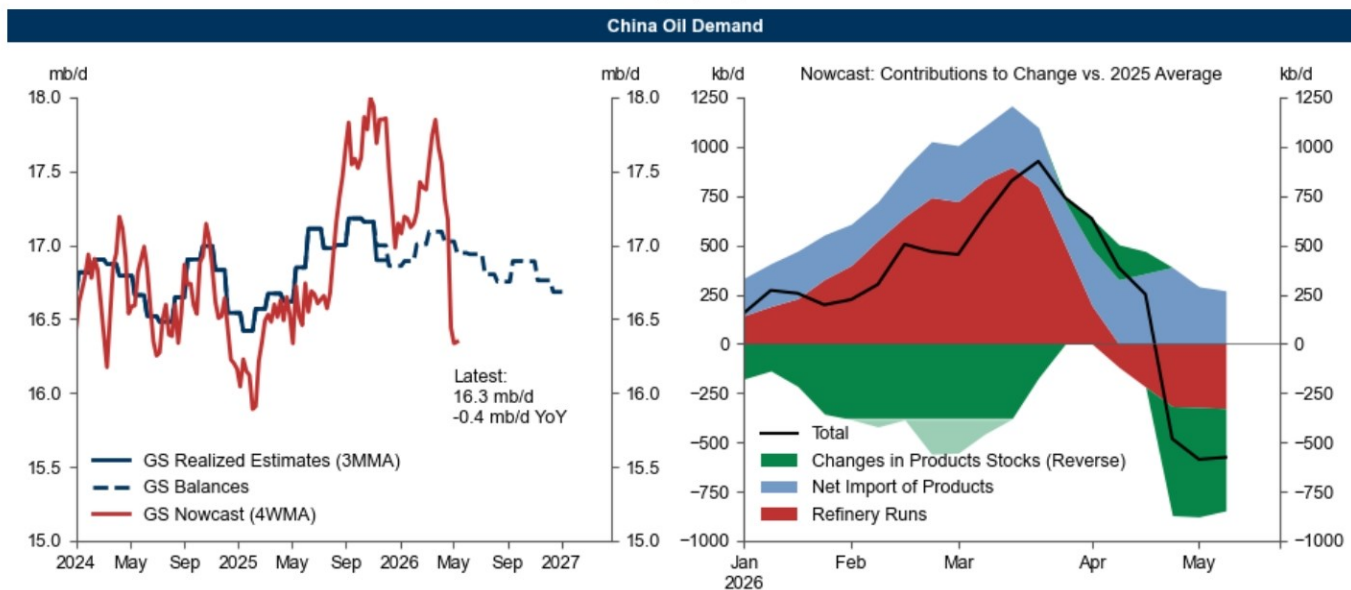
## 5) Demand

**Exhibit 18: We Estimate That Global Jet Fuel Demand in May Will be 101kb/d Softer Year-Over-Year, or 6% Below Trend**

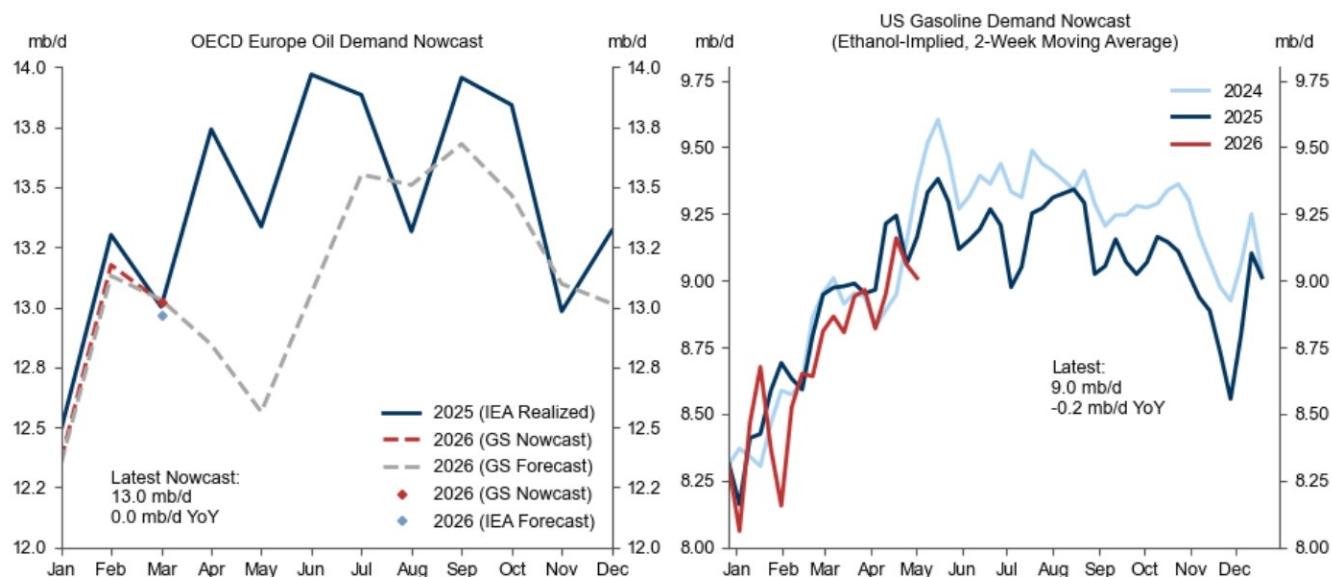


Source: EIA, OAG, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

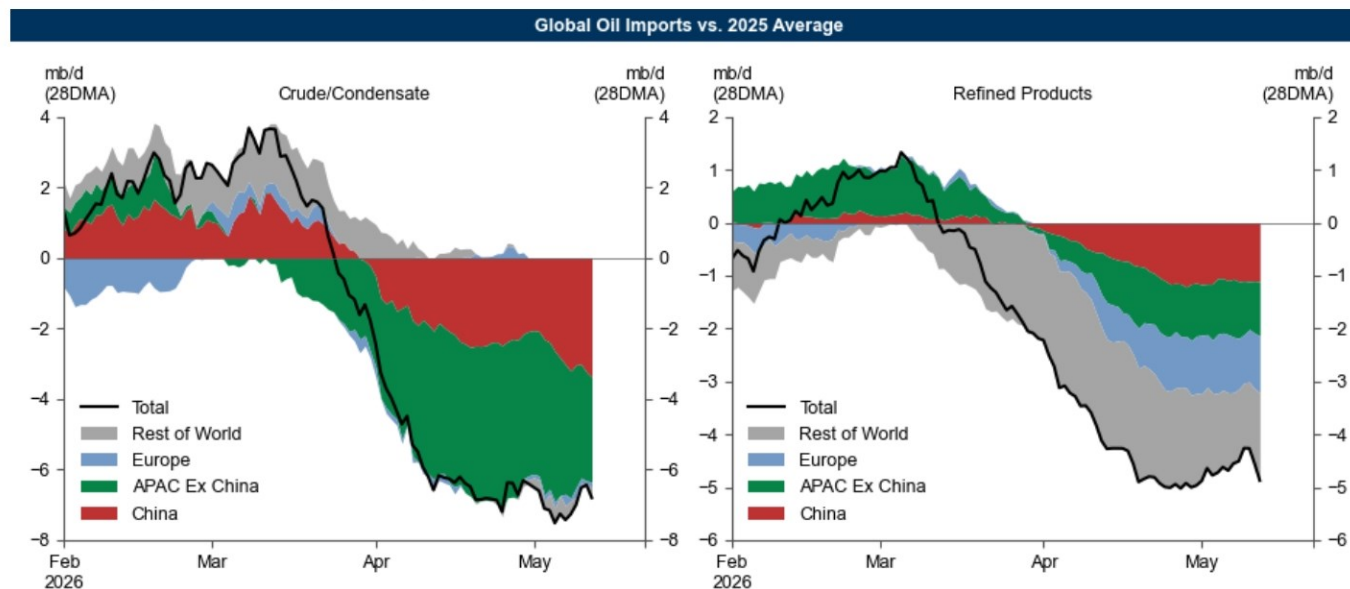
**Exhibit 19: Our China Oil Demand Nowcast Remains 1.5mb/d (8%) Below Its Mid-March Level**



Source: IEA, S&P, Kpler, GTT, Oilchem, MySteel, Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

**Exhibit 20: US Gasoline Demand Remains Resilient at Just 0.2mb/d Below Its Year-Ago Levels**


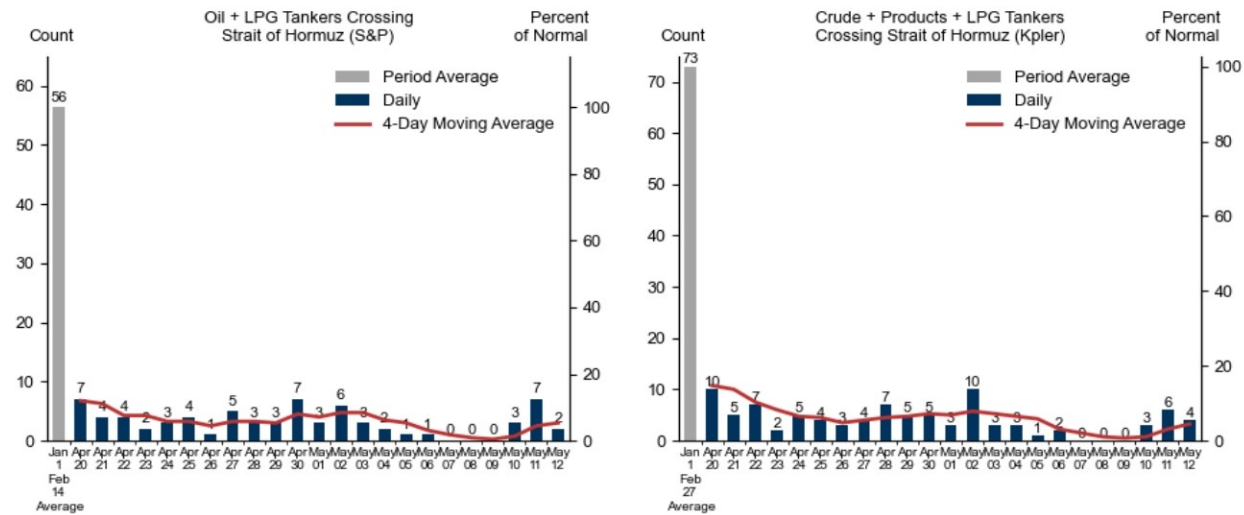
Source: IEA, S&P, Kpler, GTT, Oilchem, MySteel, Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

**Exhibit 21: Asia-Pacific Crude/Condensate Imports Are Down 6.6mb/d from 2025 Average Levels; Global Refined Products Imports Declined By 0.5mb/d Since Last Week**


Refined products include LPG.

Source: Kpler, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

**Exhibit 22: While Satellite Data on Strait of Hormuz Crossings Are Affected by AIS Signals Disruptions in the Region, Various Sources Point to Severe Disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz Flows**



We consider both “laden” and “ballast” vessels.

Source: S&P Global Commodities at Sea, Kpler, Goldman Sachs Investment Research

## Disclosure Appendix

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